Business Travel Policy

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Owner: Finance Team

Covers booking tools, airfare/lodging guidelines, international travel approval, travel insurance, and duty-of-care support.

SECTION 1: Purpose and Scope

This policy provides guidelines for booking and expensing business travel in a way that balances employee comfort, cost control, and duty of care for every employee traveling on company business.

SECTION 2: Booking Travel

All business travel must be booked through the SolaraTravel booking tool so that Solara Dynamics maintains visibility into employee whereabouts for safety purposes, and so that negotiated corporate rates are applied automatically. Travel booked outside SolaraTravel is reimbursed only with prior Finance approval, and such approval is granted sparingly.

SECTION 3: Airfare, Lodging, and Ground Transportation

Employees book economy class for domestic flights and flights under 6 hours. Directors and above may book premium economy for international flights over 6 hours. Lodging should be booked at or below the SolaraTravel-recommended nightly rate for the destination city, which is reviewed quarterly to reflect current market rates. Ground transportation should favor ride-share or public transit over rental cars where practical, though rental cars are approved when they are the more cost-effective or practical option for the trip.

SECTION 4: International Travel Approval and Safety

International business travel requires VP approval and at least 10 business days' advance notice to allow time for visa and safety review, including a check against current government travel advisories for the destination. Employees traveling internationally are automatically enrolled in the company's travel insurance and emergency assistance program described in Section 5.

SECTION 5: Travel Insurance

All company-booked business travel, domestic and international, includes travel insurance covering trip interruption, medical emergencies, and emergency evacuation at no cost to the employee. Coverage details, including the insurer's policy number and 24-hour contact information, are available from the People & Culture Team upon request and are also included in the SolaraTravel booking confirmation email.

SECTION 6: Combining Business Travel with Personal Time

Employees may extend a business trip for personal time ('bleisure' travel) with manager approval, provided doing so does not increase the cost of company-booked airfare compared to the business-only itinerary. Personal-day expenses (lodging, meals, transportation) during the extension are the employee's responsibility and are not covered by travel insurance, which applies only to the business portion of the trip.

SECTION 7: Travel Advances

Employees without a corporate card who require funds before a trip may request a travel advance of up to $500 through Finance, to be reconciled against actual expenses in SolaraExpense within 30 days of return. Unused advance funds must be returned to Finance at the time of reconciliation.

SECTION 8: Duty of Care and Emergency Contacts

Employees traveling on company business have access to a 24/7 emergency travel assistance line, provided at booking through SolaraTravel, for medical, safety, or logistical emergencies while traveling. Employees are encouraged to save this contact information before departure rather than searching for it during an actual emergency.

SECTION 9: Frequently Asked Questions

Can I keep airline miles or hotel points from business travel? Yes, employees may keep personal loyalty program rewards earned on business travel booked through SolaraTravel, provided doing so does not increase the cost of the trip to the company.

Do I need approval for a short domestic trip to see a client? Domestic travel does not require the VP approval required for international travel in Section 4, but should still be booked through SolaraTravel and follow your manager's normal approval process for time away from other duties.

What if my flight is canceled while traveling internationally? Call the 24/7 emergency travel assistance line described in Section 8 first; the travel insurance coverage in Section 5 also applies to trip interruptions such as cancellations.

SECTION 10: Roles and Responsibilities

The Finance Team owns this policy and the SolaraTravel booking tool, and reviews travel advances and high-cost bookings. Employees are responsible for booking through SolaraTravel, following the class-of-service guidelines in Section 3, and reconciling any travel advance within 30 days of return.

Managers approve travel requests for their direct reports and confirm the trip's business purpose. VPs additionally approve all international travel, consistent with the safety review requirement in Section 4.